Qanooni flew with Lambah to New Delhi one hour after signing the agreement. This, according to Lambah, was a clear signal to the rest of the world on where India stood.[148] This was followed by Abdullah, Dostum, and Karzai's visit to New Delhi in 2002, and the fact that India was the first country to reach Kabul after the fall of the Taliban. The devil, however, lay in the detail.

The world knew that India stood behind the UF, and that was the problem. Instead of being an effective conciliator, India was a partisan in the conflict, and from that perspective, it compromised its partisan policy at Bonn. In the wake of Pakistan's support to the US, the partisans had been undermined, leaving Lambah with few policy options to pursue. From the very beginning, Lambah supported the idea of a Pashtun president and found Karzai an acceptable candidate whom India could work with.[149] Despite having supported Qanooni throughout the civil war, India relented under US pressure and wanted to ensure close cooperation between Lambah and Dobbins, and helped pave the way for Karzai's rise. Though an important role in its own right, even on this issue, it was Iran's Javad Zarif's short one-to-one meeting with Qanooni, after the midnight session, that made the difference, and not necessarily the advice that came from Lambah.[150] Most participants believed India was simply supporting its proxies along with Russia and Iran.[151] For any deal at Bonn, it was imperative to strike a political equilibrium not just inside Afghanistan but also outside (thus Dobbins and Brahimi's decision to bring Moscow, New Delhi and Tehran on board on Karzai's candidature before they went on to pressurise Qanooni). And to that effect, India's presence antagonised Pakistan, which was on the frontlines in the war on terror, even if it played a limited role in the conference itself.[152] As for India, despite having negotiated his way into the conference, in a candid lunch meeting with Dobbins, Lambah acknowledged the India-Pakistan competition in Afghanistan and promised that his government would move cautiously on expanding its strategic presence in order to make sure that India was on the same wavelength as the US.[153]

India's presence at the conference had run into obstacles from the outset. New Delhi had been excessively focused on the UF and to a limited extent, on the Rome Group. As a senior Afghanistan analyst working for India's Ministry of Defence put it, 'once Operation Enduring Freedom happened we got in